Whenever a new challenge has come along during my career, my first instinctive reaction is to suddenly find myself feeling like a schoolboy again. That was definitely true as I prepared to join up with a full England squad for the first time. I was going to be working alongside big-name senior players like Paul Gascoigne, David Seaman and Alan Shearer. I was just twenty, but at that moment I felt even younger, like a kid who'd been given the chance to meet his heroes. These were the players I'd grown up watching on television and, all of a sudden, I had to get ready to train with them ahead of a World Cup qualifier.

At United, Alex Ferguson was great. He was genuinely pleased for me, and told me just to go down and enjoy myself:

'If you get the chance, play well. Just play like you have been doing for us at United.'

I took him at his word. I met up with the rest of the squad at Bisham Abbey and my first session with Glenn and with England was the best I'd ever trained in my life. I was beating players, getting my crosses in, every single pass reached its man. I even stuck a couple of shots away past David Seaman into the top corner. It was the kind of training session you'd have in a dream; it was a little bit weird just how perfect it was.

I don't know how much it had to do with impressing him in training but for his first game in charge as England manager, Glenn Hoddle put me in the starting line-up. Of course, it helped that there were players around me who I knew well, like Gary Neville, Gary Pallister and Paul Ince. And we made a great start: Gary Nev and I were both involved in the build-up to the first goal, which was scored by Nicky Barmby. A few minutes later, Gazza had got a second and we weren't going to lose it from there. In the second half, Alan Shearer got a third. As debuts go, it wasn't spectacular but I felt as if I belonged straight away. I'd helped set up that third goal for the captain as well. Perhaps because I hadn't had years of looking forward to international soccer, nerves weren't a problem and I'd just got on with playing my game, like Mr Ferguson had told me to. On September 1 1996, on a Sunday afternoon in a city called Kishinev, on a bumpy field in front of about 10,000 people, I became an international soccer player.

Glenn Hoddle must have been pretty pleased, too. I played in every game of the qualifying campaign for France 98 that, thirteen months later, found us needing a draw in Rome against Italy to go through as group winners. After we'd lost 1–0 to Italy at Wembley, everybody had assumed we would have to